

Week Five Textbook Synopsis

SP25_CO5740_Moen

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Olsen's text is a good text - it balances secular psychological ideas with Christian pastoral counseling. From the reading, the number one thing that I took from it was that the family must be viewed as a whole unit. What I mean is that there are several examples of therapy cases in the book - and whenever there is a problem child or problem parent, the system theory says that you need to view the problem in the context and scope of the entire family - not just one person. Thus, we need the entire family to come to the therapy in order for things to change.

The book's strength is that it is using very logical techniques and ideas and theories that can be viewed as secular or pastoral. This allows us to not just praise the Lord and not use our minds, but allows us to have rock solid ideas that work in the real world. The book's strength is that it shows real life examples that allow us to get a better idea of what families are like in the world. For example, I never thought that a wedding can be a nightmare because of a feud between family members. Also, I didn't think that a child's sexual escapades can be caused by the parents' own sinister desires for it and their projection of it onto the child. I believe it is very important to understand that families are interconnected and each member of the family affects the others.

The book, therefore, says that change must happen in increments. We cannot fix the family's problems in one session - they need to have around 10 sessions. And the reason why it cannot change too fast is because it is a system - homeostasis occurs, and we need to break the stability and routine in a small way, a little at a time.

I think the book's weakness is actually that they do not make the text more suited for pastoral counseling. For example, there are no bible verses quoted. Also, the word "pastor" is not used as often as I'd like.

I believe that this book can improve my ministry and guide me on the path of being a counselor by showing me that I need to look at the context of the problem. If there is a problem child, I cannot blame the child and put him down and destroy him. I need to view him as a victim, who needs others to help him. The book showed me that some children who have evil tendencies, actually just need more support from his family and school. It is a sinister thing for a teacher or parent to be culpable for making the child behave wrongly and be broken. I learned that I need to have sympathy on the problem children, and understand that with love and care, even the bad kids or bad parents can become good.

I found it so interesting that the two psychologists or counselors almost exalted the problem child in the example in the book. It was so one-sided that the author had to make the comment - do we always have to go one step away from the problem person? For example, the parents of the child? But if that is so, then don't we need to look at the parents of the parents of the child? And etc.? Thus, I learned that I must develop my own style and strategy in each counseling situation I face, and I cannot rely on rigid rules. This is true because other books say different things. For example, the previous books we read in the Counseling class say that we need short-term counseling - but none of that is stated in this book.

Therefore, I must learn to develop my own technique and heuristics in dealing with families and counseling problems. Although this book is very good, it is not perfect. We must look to Christ and rely on Christ to get the right result, and we can never be perfect. I wish that this book talked more about the theology of counseling, but I believe that I can infer it from the book.